ing 12 coaches and injuring eight passengers, the NIA was quickly notified. A technical team from the Railways has also raised suspicions of sabotage. Echoing one of the theories floated after the tragic Balasore train mishap of June 2023, investigators believe that a miscreant could have interfered with the signalling system.

Unfortunately, giving such incidents a communal angle, Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader Kapil Mishra on September 22 sought to advance a Hindu right-wing narrative prevalent on social media. "These incidents are not mere accidents.... We can label this as rail jihad," he posted on X. This was the day when a fish plate—an iron plate used to join rails—was found loose on a track in Surat. As it turned out, the two trackmen and a private contractor who had allegedly staged the sabotage for rewards bore the names Subhash Podar, Manish Mistry and Shubham Jayswal. The very next day, another trackman was arrested for allegedly setting off 10 detonators on the route of a special army train in Madhya Pradesh's Khandwa. With many such cases being traced back to their own employees, some zonal railways are also learnt to be looking inwards. But Shiv Gopal Mishra, secretary general of the All India Railwaymen's Federation, insists that a "false narrative is being created". "A railway employee lives and dies by a code, and that code is safety of train operations," he says. "The truth will emerge after investigations are complete."



"THE NIA IS INVOLVED AND WE ARE ALSO IN TOUCH WITH THE STATE POLICE TO SEE TO IT THAT SUCH MISCREANTS ARE IDENTIFIED AND INCIDENTS ARE PREVENTED"

ASHWINI VAISHNAW
Minister of Railways

And then there are cases of simple theft. In Tamil Nadu, for instance, there have been reports of elastic rail clips, used to fasten the track with concrete sleepers, going missing. Signalling and electrical equipment or the railway track itself—the money in scrap metal often drives these thefts and can lead to derailments if not detected in time. On Vaishnaw's directions, the RPF along with local police and Government Railway Police personnel is learnt to have stepped up patrolling efforts. Bike patrols and guards have been deployed in areas prone to sabotage, ensuring quick response time. The use of CCTV cameras has been expanded, though many incidents, particularly in rural areas, highlight the need for further surveillance. In areas where juvenile involvement was detected, local authorities are engaging with communities to raise awareness about the dangers of sabotage.

Top railway officials in New Delhi now plan to rope in popular social media platforms to detect and remove harmful content. In the case of Ayaan Khan, it seems he was inspired by another YouTuber posting similar content. The rise in sabotage, whether motivated by fame, social unrest or theft, reflects a deeper vulnerability—one that must be addressed before the next act leads to a tragic outcome. ■

CHENNAI METRO RAIL

MADRAS THE MOV

THE UNION CABINET HAS GREENLIT THE CHENNAI METRO RAIL PHASE 2, TO BE COMPLETED BY 2027. WHAT THE PROJECT ENTAILS AND HOW IT WILL BENEFIT THE SOUTHERN METROPOLIS

By Vipul Grover

WHY IT'S A BOON

CONNECTIVITY
Since the first underground line inaugurated in May 2017, the Chennai Metro Rail Project has expanded to 54.1 km and 41 stations. Phase 2 will extend it to 173 km and 169 stations—alleviating traffic congestion, reducing travel time and increasing overall road safety

SUSTAINABILITY
Chennai has the second-worst record of vehicular pollution in India after Delhi, generating 3,200 tonnes of carbon dioxide per day, according to a 2020 study by the Centre for Science and Environment. The expansion of metro rail will significantly reduce carbon emissions

ECONOMIC DRIVER
The project will generate jobs—construction workers, administrative staff, maintenance personnel etc. Enhanced connectivity will stimulate local businesses and attract investment and development near new stations

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY